

LESSON 3

The Narrative Past: The Peal Perfect and Verb Syntax

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 2

Quick Summary

In Lesson 2, we moved our verbless clauses into the active present tense using the **Peal Active Participle** (e.g., *kāteb*, “writing”). We learned that by attaching shortened enclitic pronouns to the participle (*-nā*, *-t*, *-ḥnan*), Syriac forms the equivalent of the English present continuous (*kāteb-nā*, “I am writing”).

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. What is the m.sg. active participle of the root ‘-*b-d* (to do/make)?
 2. How would you say “We are going” (root: ‘-*z-l*, enclitic: *-ḥnan*)?
 3. Translate: *Šām ‘īn-tūn meltā d-Alāhā*.
 4. What happens to the enclitic pronoun in the 3rd person plural (*hennōn/hennēn*) present tense?
 5. Write “She is writing” using the root *k-t-b* and the 3rd f.sg pronoun.
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SECTION 2: THE SEMITIC PERFECT TENSE — OVERVIEW

While the participle covers the present, the **Perfect tense** covers the past (completed action). The Perfect is formed by adding *suffixes* to the root to indicate person, gender, and number. It is therefore often called the “Suffix Conjugation.”

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: The Suffix Conjugation

The Perfect tense behaves almost identically across the major Semitic languages. The core pattern is a C-a-C-a-C vocalization in the 3rd m.sg (or similar variant) followed by distinct suffixes for “I”, “you”, “we”, “they”.

- **Hebrew Qal Perfect:** קָטַב (*kātab* — he wrote), קָטַבְתִּי (*kātabtī* — I wrote).
- **Arabic Form I Perfect:** كَتَبَ (*kataba* — he wrote), كَتَبْتُ (*katabtu* — I wrote).
- **Syriac Peal Perfect:** ܟܬܒ (*ktab* — he wrote), ܟܬܒܬ (*ketbet* — I wrote).

- **Greek/Latin:** Greek Aorist (ἔγραψα) or Latin Perfect (scripsi) serve similar functions for completed past narrative actions, but without the triliteral root morphology.
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SECTION 3: THE PEAL PERFECT & NARRATIVE SYNTAX

Forming the Peal Perfect

For a strong root like *k-t-b* (write), the 3rd person masculine singular is the base form: **ktab** (he wrote). Notice the vocalization shift from the Hebrew/Arabic *a-a* to the Syriac *zero-a* (k-t-a-b) due to vowel reduction. The suffixes are added directly to the root:

- Root + *-et* (1st person) → *ketb-et* (I wrote).
- Root + *-ū* (3rd m.pl) → *ktab-ū* (They wrote).

Narrative Syntax: V-S-O Word Order

Syriac is a heavily VSO (Verb-Subject-Object) language in past narrative. When reading historical or biblical texts, the verb will almost always come first.

- *Ktab Yūḥannan meltā.* (Wrote Yukhannan a word → Yukhannan wrote a word).

The Conjunction **w-** (And)

Syriac narratives chain countless actions together using the attached conjunction **w-** (and). “And he went... and he saw... and he wrote.”

- *W-npaq Yūḥannan w-ḥza malkā.* (And Yukhannan went out and saw the king).
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SECTION 4: PERFECT TENSE PARADIGMS

1. The Peal Perfect Conjugation (Root **k-t-b**)

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	TRANSLATION	ARABIC COGNATE SUFFIX	HEBREW COGNATE SUFFIX
3 m.sg.	כתב	ktab	he wrote	kataba (كَتَبَ)	kātab (-)
3 f.sg.	כתבת	ketbat	she wrote	katabat (كَتَبَتْ)	kātbāh (כָּתְבָהּ-)
2 m.sg.	כתבת	ktabt	you (m) wrote	katabta (كَتَبْتَ)	kātabtā (כָּתַבְתָּ-)
2 f.sg.	כתבת	ktabtī	you (f) wrote	katabti (كَتَبْتِ)	kātabt (כָּתַבְתְּ-)
1 c.sg.	כתבת	ketbet	I wrote	katabtu (كَتَبْتُ)	kātabtī (כָּתַבְתִּי-)
3 m.pl.	כתבו	ktabū	they (m) wrote	kabū (كَتَبُوا)	kātbū (כָּתְבוּ-)
3 f.pl.	כתבו	ktabī	they (f) wrote	kabna (كَتَبْنَ)	-
2 m.pl.	כתבתם	ktabtūn	you (m.pl) wrote	katabtum (كَتَبْتُمْ)	ktabtem (כָּתַבְתֶּם-)
2 f.pl.	כתבתם	ktabtēn	you (f.pl) wrote	-	-
1 c.pl.	כתבנו	ktabn	we wrote	kabnā (كَتَبْنَا)	kātabnū (כָּתַבְנוּ-)

Orthography Note: Notice how the single letter Taw (ח) represents both **-t** (you, m) and **-et** (I). Context and pointing (if present) clarify the reading.

SECTION 5: NARRATIVE WORD ORDER EXAMPLES

VERB	SUBJECT	OBJECT	TRANSLATION
כתב	יוחנן	מלתא	Yukhannan wrote a word.
ktab	Yūḥannan	meltā	
שמעו	תלמידיה	קולא	The disciples heard a voice.
šma ' ū	talmīdē	qālā	

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (STRONG VERBS & TRANSITIONS)

ROOT	PEAL PERFECT (3 M.S.)	MEANING	TRANSITIONS	MEANING
מ.ב.י	šbaq (שָׁבַח)	to leave, abandon	א (w-)	and
מ.א.נ	npaq (נָפַח)	to go out, exit	כ (kad)	when, while
י.נ.נ	nṭar (נָטַר)	to keep, watch	גֵּר (gēr)	for, because (Greek γάρ)
ב.ר.ב	qreb (קָרַב)	to draw near	בָּר (tūb)	again, furthermore
א.ר.ר	rdap (רָדַף)	to pursue	הַיָּדֵן (hāydēn)	then, at that time
א.ל.א	plah (פָּלַח)	to serve, work	דֵּן (dēn)	but, however (Greek δέ)
ר.ש.ש	sgad (שָׁגַד)	to worship, bow		
ל.נ.מ	qtal (קָטַל)	to kill		
מ.ר.א	praq (פָּרַח)	to save, rescue		
מ.ר.ח	‘raq (חָרַח)	to flee		
ר.ל.ל	īled (לָדָה)	to give birth		
ר.מ.ח	‘qar (חָרַח)	to root out, dig		
מ.ל.ש	sleq (שָׁלַח)	to ascend, climb		

SECTION 7: THE STORY – PART 3

The Journey

Narrative note: The story now utilizes the VSO narrative chain to describe Yūḥannan’s past actions, transitioning from the immediate present tense of Part 2.

Sentence 1

וּכְהַנֵּן אֵלֶּם אֵלֶּם וּכְהַנֵּן אֵלֶּם w-kad ‘emar hānēn, npaq Yūḥannan. w-kad (and-when) ‘emar (he-said) hānēn (these-[things]), npaq (went-out) Yūḥannan (John). → And when he said these things, Yūḥannan went out.

Sentence 2

וְעָזַל יוֹחָנָן בֶּן־אֶרֶץ וְשִׁבָּא תַלְמִידָיו־הֵי. וְ- (and-) 'ezal (went) Yūḥannan (John) b- (in) 'ar 'ā (the-earth), w- (and-) shbaq (he-left) talmīdāw-hy (his-disciples). → And Yukhannan went in the earth, and he left his disciples.

Sentence 3

נָתַר יוֹחָנָן נֹהַר בֶּן־עֵרְהָ. נָתַר (he-kept) Yūḥannan (John) nūhrā (light) b- (in) 'ūrḥā (the-way/road). → Yukhannan kept light in the road.

Sentence 4

וְקָרֵב יוֹחָנָן לְמַלְכוּתַּת דְּמַלְכָּא בִּישָׂא. וְ- (and-) qreb (drew-near) Yūḥannan (John) l- (to) malkūttā (the-kingdom) d- (of) malkā (the-king) bišā (evil). → And Yukhannan drew near to the kingdom of the evil king.

Sentence 5

וְרַבֵּי דְּמַלְכָּא רָדַפּ לְיוֹחָנָן. וְ- (and-) rabbā (the-great-one) d- (of) malkā (the-king) rdap (pursued) l- (to) Yūḥannan (John). → And the great one of the king pursued Yukhannan.

Sentence 6

וְרָאָה יוֹחָנָן וְקָאָם קְדָם תַּרְ'א דְּמַלְכוּתָא. וְ- (and-) 'raq (fled) Yūḥannan (John) w- (and-) qām (stood) qdām (before) tar 'ā (gate) d- (of) malkūttā (the-kingdom). → And Yukhannan fled and stood before the gate of the kingdom.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Perfect Identification

Identify the person, gender, and number of the following verbs in the Perfect tense.

1. כְּתַבּוּ (ktabū)
2. שְׁבַקְתָּ (šbaqt - assuming 2nd m.sg)
3. נִתְרַתְּ (neṭrat - assuming 3rd f.sg)
4. רָאָה ('raqn)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

Conjugate the root *p-l-ḥ* (to serve) in the following forms of the Peal Perfect:

1. He served
2. They (m) served
3. I served
4. You all (m) served

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following past narrative clauses.

1. W-šbaq Yūḥannan l-malkā.
2. Rdapū talmīdē l-bīšā.
3. Npaq malkā dēn men tar ʿ ā.
4. Ktabn meltā d-Alāhā.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following past narrative sentences into Syriac transliteration. Use VSO order!

1. The evil man fled from the light. (Use **men** for “from”).
2. And Yukhannan kept the word of God.
3. When the disciples drew near, they worshipped (*sgadū*).
4. The great king saved the earth.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. Who did Yukhannan leave behind when he went out?
 2. What did the “great one” of the king do?
 3. Where did Yukhannan stand at the end of the passage?
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Section 1 Warm-Up

1. ‘*ābed*
2. ‘*āzlīn-ḥnan*
3. You all (pl) are hearing the word of God.
4. It is not used. The plural participle ending (-*īn* / -*ān*) already marks the plural unambiguously.
5. *Kātbā-hī* (or just *Kātbā*).

Exercise 1: Perfect Identification

1. 3.m.pl (They wrote)
2. 2.m.sg (You left)
3. 3.f.sg (She kept)
4. 1.c.pl (We fled)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

1. *plaḥ*
2. *plaḥū*
3. *pelḥet*
4. *plaḥtūn*

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. And Yukhannan left/abandoned the king.
2. The disciples pursued the evil man.
3. But the king went out from the gate.
4. We wrote the word of God.

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. ‘*raq barnāšā bīšā men nūhrā.*
2. *W-nṭar Yūḥannan meltā d-Alāhā.*
3. *Kad qrebū talmīdē, sgadū.*
4. *Praq malkā rabbā l- ‘ar ‘ā.*

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. His disciples (*talmīdāw-hy*).
2. He pursued (*rdap*) Yūkhannan.
3. Before the gate of the kingdom (*qdām tar ʿ ā d-malkūtā*).

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

THE PEAL PERFECT (Root š-b-q)

PERSON	SYRIAC	TRANSLIT
3 m.sg.	ܫܒܩ	shbaq (he left)
3 f.sg.	ܫܒܩܬ	šebqat (she left)
2 m.sg.	ܫܒܩܬ	šbaqt (you left)
1 c.sg.	ܫܒܩܬ	šebqet (I left)
3 m.pl.	ܫܒܩܘ	shbaqū (they left)
1 c.pl.	ܫܒܩܢ	shbaqn (we left)

VSO RULE

1. VERB	2. SUBJECT	3. OBJECT / PREPOSITION
Npaq (Went out)	Malka (The King)	men (from) ʿ ar ʿ ā (the earth)

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following 30 genuinely new high-frequency words supplement this lesson's vocabulary, focusing on

nouns related to narrative past (perfect tense) action and contexts.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܫܪܐ	šrā	verb (Peal)	to loosen, release; to dwell	III-Yodh root š-r-y
ܩܠܬܐ	palkūtā	f. noun	flight, escape	from root p-l-k (to flee)
ܩܬܠܐ	qəṭlūtā	f. noun	slaughter, killing	from root q-ṭ-l (to kill)
ܓܢܒܐ	gənūbūtā	f. noun	theft, stealing	from root g-n-b (to steal)
ܫܒܩܐ	šəbūqūtā	f. noun	abandonment, leaving	from root š-b-q (to leave)
ܢܦܩܐ	napəqūtā	f. noun	going out, exit	from root n-p-q (to go out)
ܕܡܥܐ	dəm ʿūtā	f. noun	weeping, tears	from root d-m-ʿ (to weep)
ܚܡܡܐ	ḥəmmūtā	f. noun	heat, fervor	from root ḥ-m-m (to be hot)
ܦܓܥܐ	pəg ʿūtā	f. noun	striking, blow	from root p-g-ʿ (to strike)
ܐܪܩܐ	ʿārōqā	m. noun	fugitive	from root ʿ-r-q (to flee)
ܩܪܒܐ	qərbūtā	f. noun	drawing near, approach	from root q-r-b (to draw near)
ܪܕܦܐ	rəḏpūtā	f. noun	pursuit, chasing	from root r-d-p (to pursue)
ܐܪܩܐ	ʿəlqūtā	f. noun	ascent, rising	from root ʿ-l-q (to ascend)
ܦܠܗܐ	pəlḥūtā	f. noun	service, labor	from root p-l-ḥ (to serve)

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܕܪܥܘܬܬܐ	dərəkūttā	f. noun	treading, passage	from root d-r-k (to tread)
ܐܡܕܐ	ʿamdā	m. noun	pillar, column	
ܦܪܓܢܐ	pərgānā	m. noun	authority, ruler	
ܪܥܡܘܬܬܐ	rəgmūttā	f. noun	stoning, lapidation	from root r-g-m (to stone)
ܫܡܪܘܬܬܐ	šəmrūttā	f. noun	guarding, keeping	from root š-m-r (to guard)
ܢܬܪܘܬܬܐ	nəṭrūttā	f. noun	watching, guarding	from root n-ṭ-r (to watch)
ܠܘܘܬܬܐ	kūwūttā	f. noun	substance, being	from root k-w-n (to be)
ܣܒܥܘܬܬܐ	səb ʿūttā	f. noun	satisfaction, plenty	from root s-b-ʿ (to be satisfied)
ܓܪܒܘܬܬܐ	gərbūttā	f. noun	scraping, scratching	from root g-r-b (to scrape)
ܠܥܕܘܬܬܐ	ləgdūttā	f. noun	seizing, capture	from root l-g-d (to seize)
ܫܘܒܩܢܐ	šūbqānā	m. noun	(one) abandoned	from root š-b-q (to leave)
ܐܫܬܓܠ	ʾaštəgal	verb	he was occupied	Pael perfect form
ܦܡܟܢܐ	pūmkānā	m. noun	speaker	from root p-w-m (to open mouth)
ܓܠܕܘܬܬܐ	gəldūttā	f. noun	uncovering, nakedness	from root g-l-d (to strip)
ܬܘܒ	tūb	adverb	again, furthermore	common particle
ܐܕܡܐ	ʿedāmā	preposition	until, as far as	used in past narrative

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܡܕܒܪܢܐ	mədbərānā	m. noun	leader, guide	from root d-b-r (to lead)